



ARRESTED ULFA DEPUTY COMMANDER-IN-CHIEF RAJU BARUA (LEFT); RAJKHOWA BEING PRESENTED AT THE KAMRUP CHIEF JUDICIAL MAGISTRATE COURT

jailed ULFA leaders agree to talk within the parameters of the Constitution, they would be freed to facilitate their participation." The Government decided not to oppose the bail plea of ULFA cultural secretary Mithinga Daimary and vice-chairman Pradip Gogoi, and they were granted bail on February 23. Also, in a bid to get the top jailed leaders meet inside the prison to chart out a roadmap for peace talks, ULFA's political ideologue Bhimkanta Buragohain, 70, was transferred to Guwahati Jail from Tezpur Jail. In fact, all the jailed ULFA leaders are likely to be released in phases as part of the groundwork for

starting a dialogue.

The Government is reportedly working on a package that would be offered to the ULFA once they agree for talks, which may include constitutional safeguards to Assam, prevention of illegal infiltration, an acceptable National Register of Citizens to detect illegal migrants, jobs, infrastructure development and massive royalties on natural resources to the state. Highly placed sources say that the jailed ULFA leaders have already made up their mind on talks and a split in the outfit is just a matter of time. Now the big question is whether peace will return to the

state if Barua is left out of the peace process. Though the militant leader has been isolated for a while, he still commands a sizeable section of the outfit capable of carrying out disruptive activities. The Government is hot on the trail of the elusive ULFA leader who is reportedly hiding somewhere in the Kachin-Myanmar border area. Pillai visited Myanmar recently and had discussions with the military Government for coordinated action in border areas against insurgents. Top police officials say that Barua would become more menacing now as he has realised that his battle for independent Assam has reached a dead-end. In fact, Barua and a handful of supporters are planning to derail the incipient peace process.

In the past, several attempts at achieving peace by breaking ULFA have not yielded any solution; instead it created fresh problems. First it was former chief minister Hiteswar Saikia who made many ULFA militants surrender by luring them with cash rewards and freedom. In the process, he created a state-sponsored goonda force called SULEA. Then in June 2008, the Alpha and Charlie companies of ULFA's main strike force 28 battalion announced a unilateral ceasefire in defiance of the top command.

Interestingly, many in Assam find it irrational to even begin talks with the ULFA. "Why should the Government talk with a terrorist organisation? Except Barua, all top leaders are nabbed. The Government must now try to eliminate or capture him," says one 45-year-old engineer on condition of anonymity. "If the LTTE can be finished, why not ULFA?" asks a college student.

Will the Government extend an olive branch to ULFA or decide on a military solution remains to be seen. But one thing is for sure. Choudhury's dream of a peaceful homecoming are not coming true anytime soon. Till then he must answer army jawans on his way home every day. ■

my husband's passport was seized. We pretended to be a Muslim family and said that my husband was a businessman with interests abroad. Due to my looks, everyone assumed I was a covert operative. Keeping my husband away from social gatherings because of his heavily accented Bangla, I had to cover it up by saying that it was because of the time he spent abroad. Lying all the time, we lived in a constant fear of getting caught.

Q. How do you feel when innocent people are killed by ULFA?

A. We never support killing innocent people. When arms fall into wrong hands, it results in unfortunate consequence. I have personally apologised to the families of people killed.

Q. What are the three things that Assam needs most today?

A. The jailed ULFA leaders must be released to create an atmosphere for talks. Several draconian acts like the Armed Forces Special Power Act, Disturbed Areas Act must be taken away. This conflict must be solved in a dignified way for permanent peace.